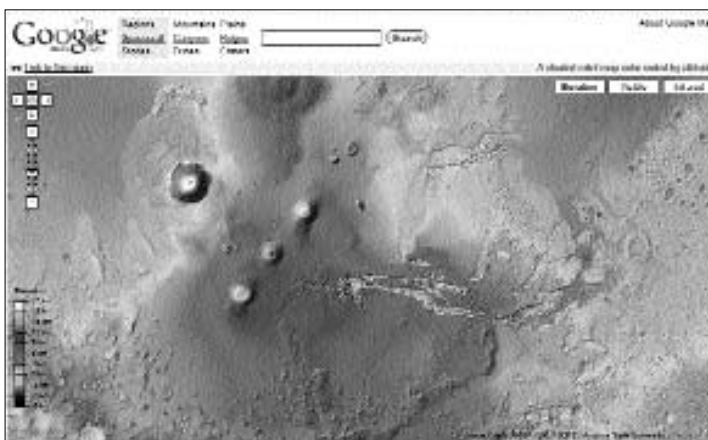


11.2 What Is Google Mars?

After Google Moon, Google expanded its online mapping service by offering ordinary users the chance to explore Mars. Google Mars' launch date happened to be the 151st birthday of Mars astronomer Percival Lowell. The images of the Red Planet are captured by Thermal Emission Imaging System (THEMIS) on the Mars Odyssey spacecraft through two different missions—Mars Global Surveyor and 2001 Mars Global Odyssey.



A view of the Martian surface as in Google Mars

Google has worked with the scientists at Arizona State University, Tempe, Arizona. The map of the Red Planet can be accessed at www.google.com/mars/ (mars.google.com works, too). Google Mars allows you to view the surface of Mars by an elevation (colour-coded altitude) map, black and white map, and an infrared map. The surface can be navigated in the same way as in Google Maps. You can switch between the elevation map, visible (black and white) map, or infrared using the buttons at the top right of the map.

What can you find on Google Mars?

The three types of maps are provided by Google Mars for three dif-